Chinese Communist Revolution (1949)

Background

Up to the mid-19th century, China had been reluctant to open its doors to the outside world.

- However, western powers such as the British, Americans, French, Dutch and Portuguese forced their way in with the **Treaty of Nanking (1842)** after the First Opium War.

Slowly, the influence of **Western ideas** started permeating into Chinese ideology.

- A section of the urban educated intelligentsia were influenced by the ideas of **liberty, equality, democracy, nationalism, communism etc**.

In **1911**, the **Qing/ Manchu Dynasty was overthrown**. The flower of **democracy** bloomed in South China.

- The rest of China was plunged into chaos with power falling into the hands of **warlords**. The Period of Warlords (1912-28) is associated with unrest and regular conflict.

In **1912, Dr. Sun Yat-sen**, the leader of the Kuomintang (**KMT**) party established a revolutionary government in South China and began the process of Chinese reconstruction. He adopted the principles of:

- Nationalism
- Democracy
- Livelihood for All

In **1921**, a group of educated Chinese youth led by **Li Dazhao and Mao Zedong**, established the **CCP** (Chinese Communist Party). Their agenda was:

- Collectivisation and regulation of industries to benefit workers.
- Land for farmers or collective farming.
- To liberate China from foreign domination.
- To end the reign of warlords.

The CCP's policies and programmes were similar to the KMT. Therefore, the two **worked together** to build a modern China.

Progress of the Revolution

- **1925 - Chiang Kai Shek captured power** and established his despotic rule after the death of Dr. Sun.
    - He was strongly anti-Communist and tried to eliminate the CCP.
- This pushed China into a **Civil War (1927-36)**.
- **1931 - Japan invaded and occupied Manchuria.**

    - While the CCP made efforts to expel them, the KMT kept on persecuting the communists, ignoring the foreign presence.
- **1934 -** The KMT forces had encircled the CCP at Jiangxi in south-eastern China. However, Mao was able to break this encirclement and retreat to Shaanxi in north-western China. This historic retreat is known as the **'Long March'**.
    - The CCP covered a distance of more than **6000 miles through 20 provinces in 368 days**.
        - Along the way, **land** was taken from landlords and rich farmers and **distributed** among the peasants.
        - For this, both violence and persuasion were used.
    - The regions controlled by the Communist produced **better results** in agriculture, law and order, land distribution and inclusion of locals in governance.
    - About 90,000 communists had started the march, but by the end only 10,000 survived. However, the CCP and Mao became extremely popular.
- **1936 - Chiang Kai Shek** was arrested by his own officers and **forced to join hands with the Communists** against the Japanese.
- **1937 - Japan orchestrated a full scale invasion** of China and hostilities continued until its final surrender in 1945.
- **1945 -** After Japan had been expelled, the **civil war resumed** and continued for four more years.
    - The KMT regime was supported by capitalist powers.
    - However, popular support was behind the CCP which received help from the Soviets as well.
- The **Communists emerged victorious** and China was proclaimed as a communist nation on **1 October, 1949**.

Reforms

Immediate Steps

China had been ravaged by decades of civil war and foreign occupation. The immediate priority of the CCP was to restore normalcy. This was achieved by:

- Provision of **basic necessities** such as food, shelter, medicine and clothing.
- **Food rationing** to counter the threat of famine.
- Bringing widespread communicable and vector-borne **disease** under control.
- Restoring **law and order** by suppressing banditry and crime.

Once order was restored, the CCP could implement its revolutionary agenda.

Gender Reform

- **Evil practices** such as child marriage, female infanticide and selling of girls into slavery, concubinage and prostitution were banned.
- The legal subordination of women to men was ended and gender **equality** was established by law.
- **Marriage** was now a **contract** which both men and women entered as equals.
- Women were also given an **equal share in family property**.
- Further, **discrimination** against women **in the workplace was prohibited**.

Land Reform

- Land was confiscated from landlords and rich peasants and distributed among the peasants through the model of collective farming.

Healthcare

- **Patriotic Health Movement:** Volunteers were sent to villages to spread awareness about the importance of hygiene, relationship between dirt and germs, explaining the mechanism of how diseases spread and preventative measures.
- **Barefoot Doctors:** 1 million volunteers were given six months medical training and sent into the Chinese countryside to provide primary care.
- **Opium Addiction:** Poppy fields for burnt and addicts were either sent to re-education camps or executed.

Education

- **Free primary education** was given to both boys and girls.
    - Additionally, **adult education camps** were organised in villages to provide literacy on a wide scale.
    - In 1949, China's literacy rate was around 20%.
    - By 1976, it had risen to 70%.
- To help with communication and writing, the government introduced a romanised phonetic form of Mandarin called **'Pinyin'**.
- This greatly eased the learning of Mandarin.

Religion

- **Mao said religion was as bad as Nazism**, and had to be eradicated.
    - Churches were destroyed, priests and monks mocked and beaten – ancestor worship was condemned as a superstition.
- In **Tibet**, the government feared the mixture of Buddhism and nationalism, and embarked on a campaign of religious persecution.
- In **Xinjiang**, the government feared the mixture of Islam and nationalism, conquered the area in a military campaign, and settled huge numbers of Han Chinese immigrants in the region to try to counter the local population.

Culture

- Mao believed that the Communist revolution should **brutally overthrow every aspect of the past**.
    - 1.5 million propagandists loyal to the party were charged with spreading the latest party message and sent to the countryside.
- The **government banned all traditional and western songs, dances, festivals and wandering poets.**
    - Instead, children were made to chant communist slogans.
- Many of Beijing's ancient houses and structures were pulled down and replaced by Soviet style block concrete housing.

Great Leap Forward

- It was Mao's vision to rapidly industrialise China and make it self sufficient in food production backfired and caused the loss of at least 20 million lives.
- It **exposed the weaknesses of centralised planning**.

Significance of the Chinese Revolution in World History

- The Chinese revolution was the **second successful practical expression of communism**.
    - Its success against the powerful and entrenched capitalist KMT regime proved the strength and efficacy of communism.
- Despite being the second communist revolution, it was **the first of its kind**.
    - This was because, for the first time **peasants** had organised themselves under the hammer and sickle.
    - The success of Chinese communism **inspired peasants** in South Asia, Southeast Asia, Africa and Latin America.
        - The Maoist movements of India, Nepal, Vietnam, Korea, Myanmar etc.were inspired by the Communist revolution in China.
- The success of the Chinese revolution **intensified efforts by capitalists to contain the spread of communism**.
    - The Korean war and the Vietnam war were manifestations of the same.
- The emergence of Communist China also **destabilised Eastern and Southern Asia**.
    - It adopted an aggressive diplomatic and military approach.
    - Territorialism became an intrinsic part of the CCP's foreign policy.
    - The Chinese occupation of Tibet, war against India and ongoing territorial disputes are manifestations of the same.

Korean War

Background

- The origins of the war lay in the fact that Korea had been **under Japanese occupation since 1910**.
    - When the Japanese were defeated (August 1945), the USA and the USSR agreed to divide the country into two zones along the **38th parallel**, so that they could jointly organise the Japanese surrender and withdrawal.
- As far as the Americans were concerned, it was **not intended to be a permanent** division.
    - The United Nations wanted **free elections** for the whole country and the Americans agreed, believing that since their zone contained two-thirds of the population, the communist north would be outvoted.
- However, the unification of Korea, like that of Germany, soon **became part of Cold War rivalry**: no agreement could be reached, and the artificial division continued.
    - **Elections** were held in the south, supervised by the UN, and the independent Republic of Korea, or **South Korea** was set up with **Syngman Rhee** as president and its capital at Seoul (August 1948).
    - The following month, the **Soviets created** the Democratic People's Republic of Korea, or **North Korea** with a communist government under **Kim Il Sung**, with its capital at Pyongyang.
- In **1949 Russian and American troops were withdrawn**, leaving a potentially dangerous situation
    - Most Koreans bitterly resented the artificial division forced on their country by outsiders, but both leaders claimed the right to rule the whole country.
- **Kim Il Sung** convinced both the **USSR and China** to provide assistance in uniting the peninsula and **invaded South Korea**.

The USA takes action

There were several reasons for President Truman to intervene:

- He took the attack as a deliberate challenge and saw it as part of a vast **Russian conspiracy to spread communism** as widely as possible.
- Some Americans saw the invasion as similar to Hitler's policies during the 1930s.
    - **Appeasement** of the aggressors had failed then, and therefore it was essential not to make the same mistake again.
- Truman thought it was **important to support the United Nations** Organization, which had replaced the League of Nations. The League had failed to preserve peace because the great powers - and especially the USA - had not been prepared to back it. Truman was determined that the USA should not repeat that mistake.

American troops in Japan were ordered to Korea. Then the USA went to the United Nations and got them to send troops to defend South Korea as well.

Stalemate

- After initially having the upper hand, the Americans were pushed back. The war dragged on for 3 years and resulted in a stalemate.
- Even though the Chinese and North Koreans were exhausted by the war and were prepared to end it by late 1952, Stalin insisted that they continue fighting, and the **Armistice was approved only in July 1953, after Stalin's death.**
- The agreement created the **Korean Demilitarized Zone** to separate North and South Korea. But officially they are **still at war** as no peace treaty has been signed.

The results of the war

For Korea itself it was a disaster:

- The country was **devastated**. About 4 million Korean soldiers and civilians had been killed and 5 million people were homeless.
- **The division seemed permanent**. Both states remained **intensely suspicious** of each other and heavily armed, and there were constant ceasefire violations.

The conflict brought a new dimension to the Cold War:

- **American relations were now permanently strained with China as well as with Russia.**
    - The familiar pattern of both sides trying to build up alliances appeared in Asia as well as Europe.
- **China supported the Indo-Chinese communists** in their struggle for independence from France.
    - At the same time, it **offered friendship and aid to under-developed** Third World countries in Asia, Africa and Latin America.
    - **'Peaceful Coexistence' agreements** were signed with India and Burma (1954).
- **Meanwhile the Americans tried to encircle China with military bases**.
    - In 1951, defensive agreements were signed with Australia and New Zealand.
    - In 1954, the US, UK, France, Australia, New Zealand, Philippines, Thailand and Pakistan, set up the South-East Asia Treaty Organization (**SEATO**).

Vietnam War

Background

- Vietnam was an **independent country till 1859**, when the French East India company captured Saigon.
- **By 1885, the whole of Vietnam was under French control.**
    - The French colonial regime introduced extensive changes in socio-cultural and economic life.
        - **Catholicism** was propagated
        - **Western education** was promoted
        - **Plantation agriculture** was started

Anti-Colonial Struggle, World War II and Vietnamese war of Independence

- The **nationalist movement** started in Vietnam in the opening decades of the 20th century. The Vietnamese started organising themselves against French colonial rule.
    - In **1930, Ho Chi Minh founded the Viet Minh Party** to fight the French colonists.
- **Japan attacked French Indochina in December 1941** and conquered all of Southeast Asia within a few months.
    - Vietnam also came under Japanese control.
    - The Vietnamese were **abandoned**. French authorities withdrew and the French citizens were also pulled out of Vietnam.
    - The Japanese rule was so oppressive that by the end of the war in 1945, roughly 2 million people, roughly 10% of the population, had died.
- As soon as the war ended, the **French returned to Saigon** and began reclaiming their colony.
    - This triggered a long drawn **conflict (1946-54)**.
- In **1954, the Geneva accords** were signed between the French and the Vietnamese.
    - The French agreed to withdraw their forces from Vietnam and recognise it as a sovereign independent nation.
- The **17th parallel** was recognised as the cease-fire line and was to remain intact till general elections scheduled for 1956.
    - **North Vietnam** was under the control of the **Communist Viet Minh**.
    - **South Vietnam** was handed over to **Emperor Bao Dai** who had been a client of the French.

America Intervenes

- The withdrawal of the French was followed by **American intervention**.
    - They wanted to contain the spread of communism in Southeast Asia.
- Prompted by US support, **Prime Minister Ngo Dinh Diem overthrew Emperor Bao Dai and declared himself the President** of South Vietnam in 1955.
    - The **war** between the north and south **resumed**.

- Gradually, the **Americans got involved directly** and by 1965, there were more than five lakh American soldiers in Vietnam.
    - Despite the large American military presence, they were unable to overcome the North Vietnamese and were **forced to withdraw** after suffering heavy losses.
- In **January 1973, the Paris Peace Treaty** was signed to bring the hostilities in Vietnam to an end.
    - The Geneva Accords were accepted by all parties.
- By **March 1973**, **all American forces had been withdrawn** and in **April 1973 Saigon fell to the Communists**.
    - On 2 July 1976, North and South Vietnam were merged to create the Socialist Republic of Vietnam.

Israel Palestine Conflict

What is the Conflict about?

At its heart, the dispute is a result of **conflicting nationalism** - the Jewish Zionist Nationalism and the Palestinian Arab Nationalism.

The key issues are:

- mutual recognition,
- borders,
- security,
- water rights,
- control of Jerusalem,
- Israeli settlements,
- Palestinian freedom of movement, and the
- The Palestinian right of return.

The **origins** of the conflict can be traced back to **Jewish immigration** and **conflict in Mandatory Palestine** between Jews and Arabs.

Despite a long-term peace process, Israelis and Palestinians have failed to reach a final peace agreement.

History and Timeline of the Conflict

Background

- From 1517 to 1917, the Ottoman Empire ruled over much of West Asia including the region of Israel.
- In the 19th century, the population in the region of Israel/Palestine was almost 87% Muslim, 10% Christian and 3% Jewish.
- In the city of Jerusalem, the population of the three communities was roughly equal.
- From all accounts, the communities lived in peace with each other.

Jewish Migration to Palestine

- In the late 19th century, an Austro-Hungarian Jewish journalist, **Theodor Herzl**, propagated the idea of a **Jewish homeland in Palestine**. This idea came to be known as **Zionism**, which found many followers among the Jews in Europe, where Jews were facing discrimination and even pogroms.
- In 1897, The World Zionist Organisation was created in the U.S. to advocate for the establishment of a Jewish homeland in Palestine.
- As a result, a **large number of Jews started flowing into Palestine**.

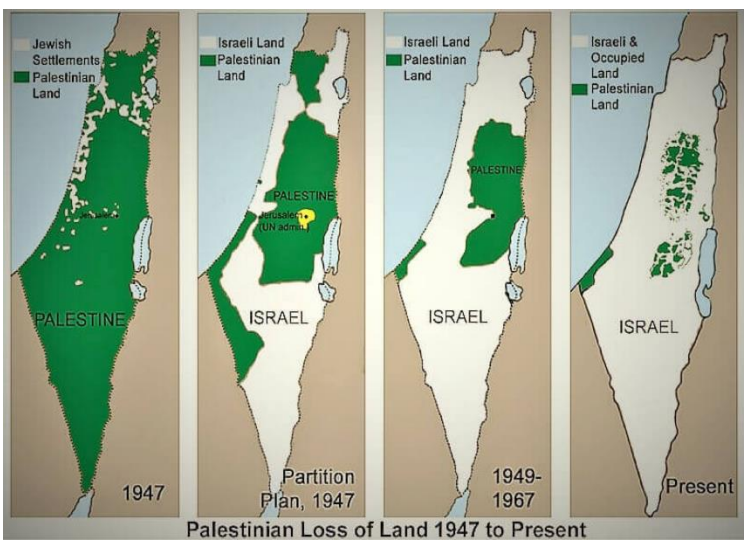
Genesis of the conflict

- **1916 - Sykes-Picot Agreement -** In a secret agreement between Great Britain and France, it was decided that Palestine would come under British rule after WW I.
- **1917 - Balfour Declaration -** Hoping to gain Jewish support for World War I, the British government announced "the establishment in Palestine a national home for the Jewish People".
- **Mandatory Palestine (1917-47) -** The British, after the First World War, established a colony in Palestine maintaining that they would rule the area until the Palestinians were ready to govern themselves.
    - This was called Mandatory Palestine as it was according to the League of Nations mandate.
- **1920s & 30s - Jewish population increased** by hundreds of thousands, facilitated by the British.
    - They began acquiring land and established Jewish agricultural settlements.
    - Tensions between the Zionists and Arabs emerged due to rising competition for resources.
    - At the same time, the spirit of nationalism also began emerging throughout the Arab world.
- **1936 - Palestinian Arabs revolted** against foreign rule, but were suppressed by the British with help from Jewish militias.
    - After the revolt, the British issued a white paper that called for the establishment of a joint Jewish-Arab state in Palestine within ten years.

- **1939-45 -** During World War II, many **Jews escaping the Holocaust came to Palestine.**
- **Tensions escalated further** and the British handed over the problem to the newly established United Nations.
- **1947 -** The **UN voted to establish separate Palestinian and Jewish states** in the region dividing Palestine.
    - Jewish people accepted the agreement and declared the independence of Israel.
    - The Arabs rejected this plan.

Arab-Israel War (1948-49):

- Arabs saw the creation of Israel as a part of a conspiracy to move them out of their land.
- Five Arab nations - **Lebanon, Syria, Jordan, Iraq, and Egypt** - declared war on Israel.
- Israel emerged victorious and now controlled more area than it would have under the UN plan.
- As part of the ceasefire agreement, the **West Bank including East Jerusalem was given to Jordan** and the **Gaza Strip became part of Egypt**.
- It was the beginning of the **Palestine refugee crisis**.
    - Over 700,000 Palestinians fled and became refugees in neighbouring Arab countries.
    - The Palestinians call this war 'al-Nakba' 'The catastrophe', as they became stateless.
- This crisis led to the formation of the **PLO (Palestine Liberation Organization) in 1964**, by refugees mostly from Jordan.
- Relations between Israel and its Arab neighbours remained poor, leading to further conflict.



Palestinian Loss of Land 1947 to Present

Suez War (1956)

- The 1956 Suez War was a **joint Israeli-British-French operation**. After Egyptian President Nasser nationalised the Suez Canal, **Israel invaded the Sinai Peninsula** and **British and French forces landed at the port of Suez**.
- Israel justified this as an attempt to **stop attacks upon Israeli civilians** and to restore Israeli **shipping rights through the Straits of Tiran**, which Egypt claimed was within its territorial waters.
- Britain and France agreed to withdraw under international pressure.
- **Israel also withdrew** from the Sinai peninsula in return for the **installation of United Nations Emergency Forces** and **guarantee of Israeli freedom of shipment**.
- The canal was left in Egyptian (rather than British and French) hands.

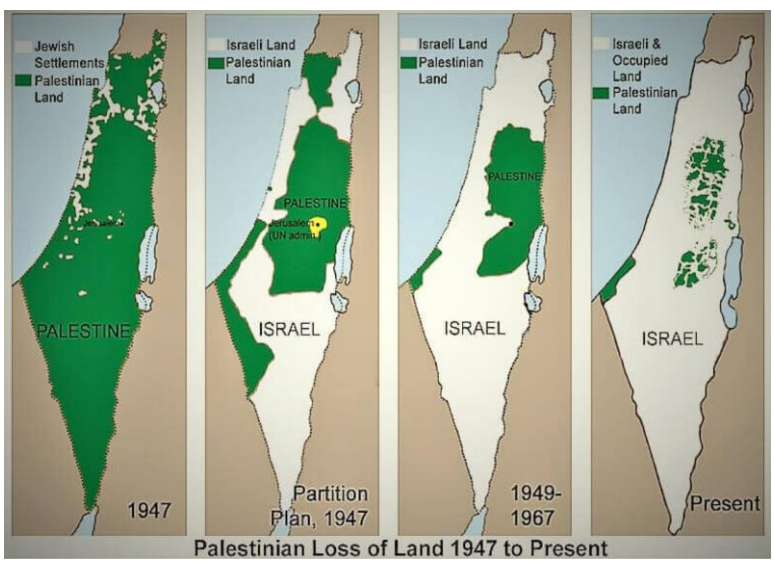
Six-Day War (1967)

The **Arab states** had not signed a peace treaty at the end of the 1948-49 war and were still refusing to give Israel official recognition. In 1967 they **joined together again in a determined attempt to destroy Israel**. Israel launched a preemptive strike against Egypt, Syria, and Jordan.

At the end of this Six-Day War, **Israel captured**:

- **Golan Heights** from Syria.
- **West Bank and East Jerusalem** from Jordan.
- **The Sinai Peninsula and Gaza Strip** from Egypt.

Gaza and Westbank are together known as 'Occupied Territories', after the 1967 war.



Yom Kippur War (1973)

- Under the UN Charter, there can lawfully be no territorial gains from war, even by a state acting in self-defence.
- Therefore, in response to the Six-Day War, the **UN Security Council adopted a resolution for 'Land for peace'** and it mandated that Israel should return the captured areas back to the defeated nations.
    - In the light of Israel's reluctance to return the captured territories, another Arab-Israeli War erupted in 1973 (Yom Kippur war).
- After initial setbacks, the Israelis were able to turn the tables. They succeeded in hanging on to all the territory they had captured in 1967 and even crossed the Suez Canal into Egypt.
- Both **the USA and the USSR** decided it was time to intervene to try to bring about a peace settlement.
    - Acting with UN cooperation, they **organised a ceasefire, which both sides accepted.**

Peace Process

Camp David Accords (1978)

- "Framework for Peace in the Middle East" brokered by the U.S. set the stage for **peace talks between Israel and its neighbours** and a resolution to the "Palestinian problem".

Israel-Egypt Peace Treaty (1979)

- Israel returned the Sinai Peninsula to Egypt (1982).
- Egypt became the first Arab nation to officially recognize Israel as a state.

Oslo Accords (1993)

- **Israel and the PLO officially recognize each** other and renounce the use of violence.
- The **Palestinian Authority** was established, which received **limited autonomy** in the Gaza Strip and parts of the West Bank.

Road Map for Peace (2003)

- The UN, EU, US, and Russia had released a road map in 2003, which outlined a clear timetable towards a Palestinian state.
- The roadmap was derailed as neither side was ready to take the first step.

Summary of the Conflict

What does Palestine want?

- It wants Israel to withdraw to **pre-1967 borders** and establish an **independent Palestine state in the West Bank and Gaza**.
- **Israel should stop all expansion of settlements** before coming to peace talks.
- Palestine wants **Palestinian refugees** who lost their homes in 1948 to be able **to come back**.
- It also demands **East Jerusalem as the capital** of the Independent Palestine state.

What does Israel want?

- Sovereignty over Jerusalem.
- Recognition of Israel as a Jewish State.
- The right of return of Palestine refugees only to Palestine and not to Israel.

The Way Forward

- The best solution is a **"two-state solution"** that would establish Palestine as an independent state in Gaza and the West Bank, leaving the rest of the land to Israel.
- The **democratization of the Palestinian society** through which new credible leadership can emerge.
- The need of the hour is to **treat this conflict as an Israeli-Arab conflict** rather than an Israel-Palestine conflict.
    - As we have seen, the conflict is not only between Israel and Palestine but also with other Arab countries such as Egypt, Jordan, Iran, Syria etc.
    - All of them should participate in the negotiations and the final agreement should be recognized formally by each one of them along with the UN general assembly and security council.

Meiji Restoration

Introduction and Background

In 1839 and 1856 Asian nations were shocked by Britain's crushing victories over China in the two **Opium Wars**. Industrialisation—it was now pretty clear—gave massive advantages to European nations, including more money and better weapons.

In Asia, China had been the dominant power and richest economy. But the British navy, using new artillery and gunboats, easily defeated China's much larger military. These wars **demonstrated that European technology had far outpaced China's**.

Across the East China Sea, the **Japanese were determined not to fall behind** the Europeans the way China had.

The result was the 1868 political transformation known as the Meiji Restoration.

- Drawing from both Western models and Japanese traditions, the **Meiji Restoration allowed Japan to develop into a modern industrial nation-state that rivalled European nations** in both military and economic power.

When the Meiji emperor was restored in **1868**, Japan was

- militarily weak;
- primarily agricultural;
- technologically backward;
- controlled by hundreds of semi-independent feudal lords;

- forced to sign treaties with western countries that limited its control over its own foreign trade and required that crimes concerning foreigners in Japan be tried not in Japanese but in Western courts.

When the Meiji period ended, with the death of the emperor in **1912**, Japan had

- a highly centralised, bureaucratic government;
- a constitution establishing an elected parliament;
- a well-developed transport and communication system;
- a highly educated population free of feudal class restrictions;
- an established and rapidly growing industrial sector based on the latest technology;
- a powerful army and navy.

Japan before the Meiji restoration

By the nineteenth century, an emperor had reigned in Japan for around 1,500 years. But from 1185 to 1868, the actual emperor held very little power.
It was the Shogunate (government run by a Shogun) that dominated Japanese politics.

- The **shogun was a military leader who held power as a hereditary dictator.** While the emperor reigned as a "god on Earth", he was really just a figurehead.

Japan was divided into **several regions controlled by daimyo**.

- **Daimyo** were feudal lords who controlled their lands with the aid of samurai.
- The **samurai** were an educated military class who were granted land in return for military service to a daimyo.
- **Peasants** (around 80% of the population) were prohibited from working any job other than farming.

The Tokugawa family took control of the shogunate around 1600, bringing some welcome stability after a period of unrest.

The Tokugawa were also **extremely suspicious of European influence**.

- In 1636, the shogun announced the **Act of Seclusion**, which made it illegal for Westerners to trade in Japan.
- Though Japanese merchants could still trade in China and Korea, the Act of Seclusion effectively cut the Japanese off from Europeans.

The fall of the Shogunate

Japan's isolationist policies worked for over 200 years, but the Tokugawa Shoguns couldn't block foreign interference forever.

- On July 8, 1853, four American naval ships under the command of **Commodore Perry** anchored in Tokyo harbour as a kind of "shall we trade or shall we fight?" message.

Since the Japanese didn't have a navy, they knew they couldn't fight even Perry's small squadron.

- They opened up negotiations with the Americans.
- Through Perry, US President Fillmore **forced Japan to open its harbours** to US trade, breaking the centuries-long prohibition against foreign trade.

The **shogun was blamed** for Japan's misfortunes and a group of lower-ranked samurai began undermining the shogun by glorifying the emperor.

- Their slogan was **Sonnō Jōi**—"Revere the emperor, Expel the barbarian."
- They attacked foreigners at Japanese ports, and caused **local uprisings** against the shogun.

The Meiji restoration

The rebellious factions increased pressure on Tokugawa Yoshinobu, the last shogun.

- **Yoshinobu stepped down**, then soon rebelled against those who had replaced him, only to be even more firmly defeated resulting in the **restoration of the young Emperor Mutsuhito 'Meiji'.**

This political revolution "restored" the emperor to power, but he did not rule directly.

- He was expected to **accept the advice of the group that had overthrown the shôgun**, and it was from this group that a small number of ambitious, able, and patriotic young men from the lower ranks of the samurai emerged to take control and establish the new political system.

They believed that the **West depended on**

- **constitutionalism for national unity**
- **industrialization for material strength, and**
- **a well-trained military for national security.**

Adopting the slogan **"Enrich the country, strengthen the army"** ("Fukoku kyōhei"), they sought to create a nation-state capable of standing equal among Western powers.

Japan becomes a nation-state

On April 17, 1868, the emperor announced the **Charter Oath** that all would swear to him.This oath represented the emperor's commitment to transforming Japan into a modern nation-state.

- **Deliberative assemblies** shall be widely established and all matters decided by open discussion.
- **All classes**, high and low, shall be united in vigorously carrying out the **administration of affairs of state**.
- **The common people**, no less than the civil and military officials, shall all be **allowed to pursue their own calling** so that there may be no discontent.

- **Evil customs of the past shall be broken off** and everything based upon the just **laws of Nature**.
- **Knowledge shall be sought throughout the world** so as to strengthen the foundation of imperial rule.

The feudal lords voluntarily surrendered to the Emperor, their fief, and became in the eyes of the law, ordinary subjects. The old warrior class Samurai also gave up their class privileges.

- In one stroke, **feudalism was abolished** which gave the way for the organisation of the state on a national basis.
- The **bureaucracy was reorganised, expanded, and opened** to those taking civil service examinations.

A change so sudden and inspired by such unselfish patriotism is rare in history.

Economic Revolution

The state played a major role in

- Expansion of agriculture (using traditional Japanese technology) and
- Expansion of manufacturing (using imported Western technology)

Agriculture:

The **abolition of feudalism and consolidation** under a strong national government that monopolised taxation, gave a strong push to the

- Extension of **farm credit**
- **Research** in indigenous farming techniques
- Diffusion of **best practices**
    - The **nationwide diffusion of seed varieties** spearheaded a substantial improvement in agricultural productivity.

Industry:

- A group of Japanese politicians known as the **Iwakura Mission** toured Europe and the USA to study their western economy, technology, and political systems.
- The result was a deliberate **state-led industrialization policy** to enable Japan to quickly catch up.
    - Government initiative dominated manufacturing because of **lack of capital and technology**.
- A **ministry of industry** was created in 1870 to establish overall economic policy and operate certain industries.
- **Model factories** based on imported technology were created to provide industrial experience, and an expanded education system offered technical training.
- Domestic industries were scaled up by **reverse engineering** the latest manufacturing machinery and technology.
- By providing political and financial security, the **government made investment in new industries and technologies possible**.

- The government **led the way** in this, building railway and shipping lines, telegraph and telephone systems, three shipyards, ten mines, five munitions works, and fifty-three consumer industries (making sugar, glass, textiles, cement, chemicals, and other important products).
- However this was very expensive, and strained government finances, so in 1880 the government **decided to sell most of these industries to private investors**, thereafter encouraging such activity through subsidies and other incentives.
- The **Bank of Japan** was established in 1882, laying the foundations for a private banking system backed up by a lender of the last resort.
- The Bank of Japan used taxes to fund model steel and textile factories.

Military Might and Imperialism

- During the era of the shogunate, each region had its own military, controlled by samurai loyal to their daimyo.
- Under the Meiji emperor, these **regional armies were replaced by a national army**, and **all male citizens were required to serve** in the military.
- The government **embraced new ideas and technology** brought to Japan by Western merchants and diplomats.
- Within two decades, **Japanese victories** illustrated the success of these military reforms.
    - They set their eyes on expanding into Korea, which was under Chinese control.
    - Japan's victory in the **First Sino-Japanese war (1894-1895)** forced China out of Korea and also gained Taiwan as a colony.
- However, Japanese control over the Korean peninsula was quickly challenged by European powers, like Russia which invaded Korea.
    - But the Japanese military had grown since the Meiji Restoration and the **Russo-Japanese War (1904-1905)** ended in victory for Japan.
- This sent shockwaves through Europe and told the world that European militaries were not invincible.
    - Over the next 15 years, Japan dominated Korea's economy as it exerted military control over the peninsula. In 1910, Korea officially became part of the Japanese empire.

The UNO

Objectives

The UN is a **legacy of the league of Nations**. In 1941 itself, the US and the UK had decided to create an international forum for disarmament, establishing peace and removing the circumstances responsible for war.

In its resolution adopted in 1945, the UN proclaimed that all **disputes** will be resolved primarily through mutual **dialogue**, and if necessary through the **intervention** of a third party or the UN itself.

The 26 founding members agreed to respect each other's **territorial integrity** and pledged that they would **not initiate any conflict**.

Further, they would work for **individual liberty, prosperity, equality, human rights and the development of poor countries.**

They would fight to remove **poverty, illiteracy and disease.**

Organs and their Functions

General Assembly:

- It is a general body in which each member country is represented. Every member can send up to 5 representatives. However, each country has one vote. Most resolutions are passed by simple majority. However some resolutions require a 2/3 majority.

United Nations Security Council:

- It is the main executive body of the UN and consists of 15 members (5 Permanent + 10 Non-Permanent). The 5 permanent members (P5) are the USA, the UK, France, Russia and China.
- The 10 Non-Permanent members are nominated for a tenure of two years on a rotational basis.
- All resolutions generally begin in the Security Council and once approved by it, are transmitted to the General assembly.
- The assent of at least 9 members, including all the permanent members is necessary to pass a resolution. If a permanent member rejects resolution, it comes to an end. This is known as the Veto Power.

The Secretariat:

- It consists of several Secretaries headed by a Secretary General. It is responsible for the day to day operations of the UN and implements the various resolutions adopted by the UNFC and General assembly.

- The Secretary General and other Secretaries are elected for a period of five years and may contest elections any number of times.

ECOSOC:

- It is meant to improve the per capita income, living standards and other human development indices of the member countries.

Trusteeship Council:

- This body looks after newly created countries or a country undergoing a crisis, which has been entrusted to it for its security and upkeep. Presently, this council is in a dormant state.

International Court of Justice:

- Its judges are appointed for a term of 9 years. It adjudicates disputes between member countries and has jurisdiction over the incidental issues arising from such disputes.

Other than the six organs, the UN has **15 sister organisations** for different objectives. Some of them include the ILO, UNESCO, UNHRC, FAO, ARC, etc.

Critical Appraisal of the UNO and its functioning

Over the past 70 years many resolutions have been moved in the UN with a modest degree of success.

In **1948** itself, **Syria, Yugoslavia and Iran successfully brought resolutions against France and the USSR** alleging that these two countries were violating their territorial integrity and interfering in their internal politics. The UN passed a resolution, directing the aggressors to withdraw their troops. This was the first major success of the UN.

Between the 1950s and 1990s, many such issues were brought before the UNSC and were resolved successfully, including the **Iraq-Kuwait Conflict (1990)** in which Kuwaiti security was guaranteed by the UN and finally its sovereignty was restored.

The **sister organisations** of the UN have played a significant role in **reducing poverty, child mortality, famine, malnutrition, human trafficking etc**. They have also worked to improve the condition of women especially in Asia and Africa.

UNESCO has played an important role in **increasing literacy** and has excelled in protecting the tangible and intangible **heritage** of the world.

During the **Cold War period**, the UN was successful in **toning down aggression** and made giant strides towards the goal of **disarmament**.

However it was **not always successful** in preventing conflict. Major wars were fought in Korea, Vietnam, the Middle East and South Asia.

The task of **disarmament remains incomplete** and in recent years countries have started building deadly weapons.

In the socio-economic sphere, the UN has been ineffective in arresting the rise of **inequality**.

The UN has also received criticism for the **flawed structure of the UNSC**.

- The **veto powers** of the P5 members are an important reason for several of its failures. Notably, the Vietnam War, the Israel-Palestine dispute, the Afghan crisis, the Cuban missile crisis etc. gravely threatened global security while the UN stood by helplessly.

It is seen that **national interest** prevails over international cooperation within the Security Council.
Lack of a permanent army is another reason for its failure. Member countries do contribute their troops for peacekeeping operations, however such contributions are voluntary.
Funding is another major issue which limits the U.N.'s effectiveness. Countries like the US, Britain, France and Japan contribute the most, because of which they dominate the agenda of the UN.

Future of the UN

Most observers suggest that the next few decades will be significantly different from the 20th century which was characterised by a bipolar world, bloc politics and eventually American ascendancy.

In the 21st century, American hegemony would be challenged and a **multipolar world** would emerge in which China, India, Japan, Germany, Africa and the Arab world would be at the forefront of economic development and military might.
Therefore, it becomes necessary to reform the global governance structure, especially the UN and its Security Council to reflect the emerging reality. Experts have made a few suggestions as follows:

- To **enlarge the size of the permanent members by including the G4** i.e India, Japan, Germany and Brazil.
- To i**nclude at least one Arab and one African country** as a permanent member of the UNSC.
- To **remove the veto powers** of the P5 members.
- To **enlarge the UNSC itself without any permanent members**.
- To strengthen the General assembly and **do away with the UNSC**.
- **Funding structure should be rationalised** so as to avoid the monopoly of a few powerful countries.
- A **permanent army should** be created consisting of mandatory contributions from all members.